

Thirsting for Success

Jayanti Khan Chauhan has set her sights on newer markets and is focussing on carbonated drinks to expand Bisleri's footprint

BY KRISHNA GOPALAN

PHOTO BY MANDAR DEODHAR



THERE HAVE BEEN occasions in business history when a brand becomes generic to a product category—think Xerox for photocopying, Cadbury for chocolates—you get the drift. And for any brand that does so, it is a good place to be in. For Jayanti Khan Chauhan, Bisleri, synonymous with packaged drinking water in India, is exactly that. And she isn't complaining. Her company's revenue has crossed ₹2,000 crore and continues to grow. "I am blessed to have a proficient team. My success in managing diverse responsibilities is because of their profound comprehension of the ever-evolving consumer landscape," says the Vice Chairperson

of Bisleri International.

That said, she doesn't want to rest on her laurels. Bisleri continues to look at newer markets and ways to enhance its user base. It is a tough business to be in with over 6,000 brands in a large unorganised market. Chauhan, who studied product development at Fashion Institute of Design and Merchandising in Los Angeles, has a soft corner for Vedica, a premium water brand that "today sells hundreds of thousands of cases". It makes her happy that the brand has defied the initial scepticism. "Over time, we have managed to cultivate a robust sales force that has [been pivotal] to Vedica's ascendancy," she says.



JAYANTI KHAN CHAUHAN

39, Vice Chairperson, Bisleri International

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| 53

The other focus area for Chauhan, who grew up listening to the clinking of soft drinks bottles (her family owned brands like Thums Up and Limca then, which they later sold to Coke) is carbonated soft drinks, where she fights Coca-Cola and PepsiCo. Her brands include Bisleri Pop, Bisleri Rev and Limonata. Chauhan will have her hands full in the time to come with more capacity for the water business and taking Bisleri outside India. "We are evaluating opportunities to expand to other countries in the Middle East," she says. While she understands how critical that part is, the basics never miss her mind. "We aspire to foster a more transparent work culture to enhance our efficiency and cohesiveness." With Chauhan at the helm, that seems quite achievable. **BT**

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